THE PREETHA CHRONICLES

A Longitudinal Study of UvrC, Friendship, Questionable Hairdressing Decisions, and the "Biscuit" Phenomenon at CSIR-CFTRI, Mysore

Original Research Article • Farewell Special Edition

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Manuscript status: Accepted with unconditional emotional approval and minor revisions to the hairstyle methodology.

A mock scientific tribute to the work, friendships, adventures, and everyday moments that made Preetha's PhD years unforgettable.

Abstract

Background: Doctoral research is widely recognized as a demanding period involving experimental uncertainty, scientific troubleshooting, and the persistent pursuit of answers. The contributions of friendship, spontaneous parties, questionable aesthetic decisions, and strategically motivated canteen visits to doctoral survival remain less thoroughly documented.

Objective: This article documents the multidimensional PhD journey of Preetha, a researcher in the Department of Microbiology at CSIR-CFTRI, Mysore, whose investigations into UvrC protein were accompanied by exceptional hospitality, adventurousness, emotional expressiveness, and a remarkable ability to make people feel at home.

Methods: A longitudinal observational approach incorporated laboratory experiments, protocol discussions, campus walks involving fruit collection, canteen-based biscuit surveillance, recreational activities at Quarters H-14, and a notable cosmetic intervention involving French bangs administered under laboratory conditions. Social observations included Pictionary, dumb charades, festival celebrations, and friendship formation.

Results: Preetha demonstrated loyalty, compassion, hard work, social connectivity, and a talent for making ordinary moments special. Quarters H-14 emerged as a major centre of collective activity, while the laboratory was unexpectedly associated with both scientific investigation and an unsuccessful hairdressing experiment.

Conclusion: Preetha's doctoral legacy extends beyond scientific work to include a durable network of friendships, shared laughter, unforgettable gatherings, and an exceptional capacity to transform ordinary spaces into places of belonging.

1. Introduction: The Arrival of a Senior Scientist and a Future Legend

Every research institute has its own history. Some is recorded in publications and theses; some survives in the memories of people who spent their formative years within its walls. Preetha's story belongs to both categories, although certain chapters may be better preserved through photographs and carefully worded disclaimers.

For many of us, the story began in the laboratory, where Preetha was first known as a senior researcher. Over time, the professional connection grew into something more personal. The protocols remained important and experiments continued, but conversations grew longer, laughter became more frequent, and colleagues gradually became part of one another's lives.

Preetha was a scientist investigating UvrC, an adventurous traveller, a passionate photographer, a lover of vibrant colours, and a friend who believed that life's moments deserved to be celebrated. Emotional, expressive, occasionally moody, and unmistakably herself, she brought loyalty, compassion, and joy to the people around her.

Her PhD was therefore not merely a period of scientific training. It was also the setting for friendships, adventures, and small rituals that made CFTRI feel like home.

2. Materials and Methods: A Protocol for Friendship Formation

2.1 Study setting and materials

The study was conducted across the CFTRI campus, laboratory, canteen, residential quarters, and travel destinations associated with the group. Materials included UvrC protocols, experimental troubleshooting, a trusted group of friends, Pictionary materials, dumb charades, a camera, seasonal fruit trees, and Quarters H-14—the unofficial headquarters of togetherness.

2.2 The French Bangs Experiment (FB-01)

Objective: To introduce French bangs through an improvised laboratory-based hairdressing intervention. Hypothesis: Confidence and enthusiasm would be sufficient to produce a successful hairstyle. Method: A haircut was attempted in the laboratory environment without adequate validation or a robust pre-experimental risk assessment.

2.3 The biscuit surveillance protocol

The term "biscuits" was adopted as an internal code word for an individual of particular interest



Figure 1: *A*, The panel here depicts the author in a kerala traditional saree in her hometown celebrating onam. *B,* The panel here shows the author wearing a very pretty blue saree (now confiscated by her mother) in fellow labmates marriage. The pose here is a very common pose of looking down to create a aesthetic pic. *C,* The panel here shows the author in yet another kerala traditional dress known as "pattu pavada" during MFT department ayudha puja. *D,* This is a rare pic of the author faking to drive a car, as the author inspite of having a car licence doesn't know how to drive a car to save a life

to the group. Canteen visits consequently acquired a secondary observational purpose. The exact number of biscuit-related missions could not be established, but the persistence of the term suggests considerable cultural stability.

2.4 Quarters H-14 social experiments

Quarters H-14 served as a principal gathering place for parties, conversations, and celebrations. Pictionary tested the limits of visual communication; dumb charades tested the limits of gestural interpretation. Both activities produced laughter, friendly competition, and memories that outlasted the games themselves.

3. Results: Major Findings from the Preetha Study

3.1 From laboratory senior to irreplaceable friend

Relationships rarely announce the moment they change. One day, someone is simply the senior working in the laboratory; over time, she becomes the person whose home is everyone's gathering place and whose presence changes the atmosphere of a room. Preetha's warmth and loyalty made this transition feel natural.



Figure 2: *A,* The author's holi celebration with fellow labamtes; *B,* The author is trying to lift very fat labmate; *C,* The kegs n pegs ritual visits; *D*, the author was part of a picinic celebration for a senior; *E,* The author's last ayudha puja with the fellow labmate *F,* The author and the labmate just wanted to wear nice clothes and go out; *G,* New year (2026) celebration in the lab; *H,* The author witnesses great support from her friends on her big day; *I,* The author and the labmates again looking for a reason for getting ready.

3.2 Quarters H-14: The unofficial department of happiness

H-14 was more than a residential quarter. It became a social hub where friends assembled, festivals were celebrated, and ordinary evenings turned into stories. Preetha's hospitality made people feel welcome—not as visitors, but as people who belonged.



Figure 3: *A*, The panel here shows the 2026 vishu celebration organised by the author at her quarters H-14; *B,* The panel here shows the different food items prepared by the authors, famously known as the "sadhya"; *C,* The panel depicts the birthday celebration of the authors organised by authors's friends.

3.3 The French bangs experiment

The author due to shortage of time and money asked fellow labmates Deeksha and Sangeetha to give her a French bang as they were trending. The said labmates over sold themselves and made the author believed that are perfect for the job. Fig. 4 here shows the result of the in-house experiment.



Figure 4: The figure here shows the aftermath of an impulsive decision made by author to trust her labmates Deeksha and Sangeetha to deliver their over claimed talent as hair dresser. The end result can be seen to be no where upto the deliverables claimed and infact turned out to be a disaster.

3.4 The biscuit hypothesis

The canteen-based biscuit phenomenon deserves independent recognition. A visit for refreshments could also become an opportunity for observation, a shared glance, and a later discussion. “Biscuits” became a shorthand for an entire collection of memories, demonstrating how an inside joke can preserve a history in a single word.

A



B



Figure 5: *A,* The panel here shows the CFTRI canteen “chai”. The dopamine that keeps everyone running. *B,* The panel here shows the cartoonic representation of the infamous “biscuit” described thoroughly in the manuscript that kept the author motivated to visit the canteen during the tea time.

3.5 Campus biodiversity and long-walk sampling

Long walks across campus involved conversations, fruit-tree spotting, and the collection of guava, avocado, and star fruit. These expeditions required no formal agenda. Sometimes the destination was a fruit-bearing tree; sometimes it was simply the end of a good conversation.

A



B

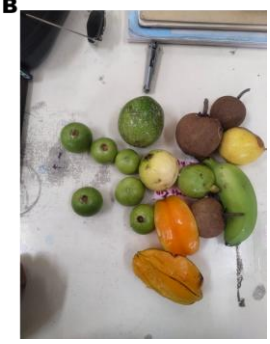


Figure 6: *A,* The author is seen under a campus tree with the fellow labmate with whom author is known to take long walks in the campus. *B,* The figure here shows all the fruits plucked by the author and the walking parter from the campus. The fruits include guava, star fruit, chikku and raw banana

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3.6 Adventure, photography, and a colourful life

Preetha’s enthusiasm for Himalayan trekking, Goa, and Gokarna reflected a desire to explore life beyond the laboratory. Her photography preserved the people and places she valued,

while her love for vibrant colours expressed her energetic outlook. Her affection for dogs and cats reflected a gentler, compassionate side of the same adventurous spirit.

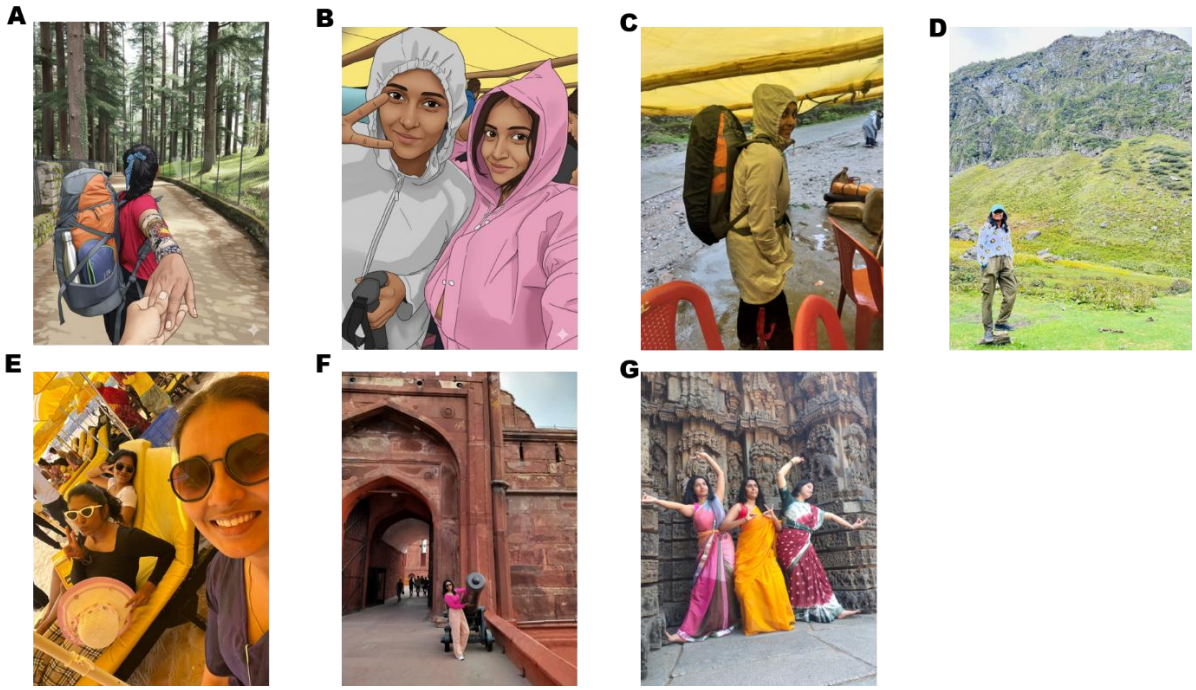


Figure 7: *A,* The pic was taken in manali just before the hampta pass trek; *B,* A cartoonic representation of the author and fellow labmate taking a selfie at the start point of the trip; *C,* The author is all set to begin the monsoon trek; *D,* The author posing in the middle of spiti valley; *E,* The author is seen here enjoying with her friends in goa beach; *F,* The author is seen here posing with a canon in the red fort in delhi; *G,* The author is seen here depicting a dance step with fellow labmates in somnathapuram temple wearing traditional sarees.

3.7 Personality analysis: A complex but highly valued system

Preetha's defining qualities included loyalty, hard work, emotional expressiveness, compassion, adventurousness, hospitality, and a talent for making other people feel special. She could be moody and intensely expressive, yet these qualities coexisted with generosity, joy, and a strong instinct to care for others. Her influence arose from the combination of these traits rather than any single characteristic.

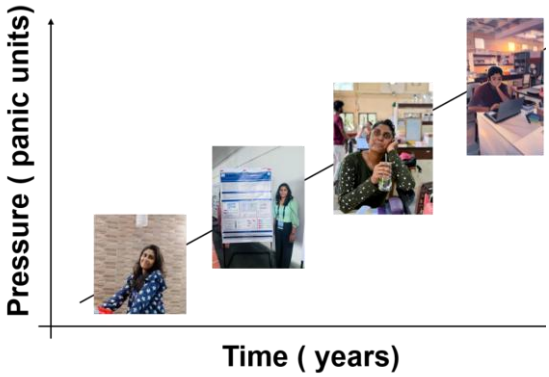


Figure 8: The graph here shows the personality development of the author in the function of pressure measured in panic units against time in years. It was observed that the author was very fun loving and cheery at the beginning of the 1st year, followed by very serious dedication towards research. This dedication later led to complete loosing of mind causing abnormal behaviour and expression. Later, the author realised that nothing can be changed and she has deadlines to deliver so better get back to work.

4. Discussion: The Human Side of the PhD

A thesis can document questions, methods, findings, and conclusions.

It cannot easily record how a senior becomes a friend, how a failed haircut becomes a running joke, or how a home becomes the place everyone remembers when thinking of the happiest parts of a PhD.

The French Bangs Incident shows how shared mistakes become part of a group's identity. Pictionary and dumb charades demonstrate how simple activities can generate disproportionate joy. The biscuit phenomenon illustrates how a private joke can become shorthand for an entire collection of memories. H-14 shows that a place becomes important because of the people who gather there.

Preetha's scientific work on UvrC demanded patience and discipline. Her life at CFTRI also involved creating belonging, celebrating others, and building friendships that made difficult days easier. These relationships were not merely activities surrounding the PhD; they were among the experiences that gave the journey its personal meaning.

5. Limitations and Future Directions

This retrospective study is limited by its anecdotal design. The exact number of laboratory conversations, biscuit observations, fruit-collection expeditions, and Pictionary disputes could not be determined. The cosmetic outcome of the French Bangs Experiment was assessed qualitatively because standardized measurements of hairstyle-related disappointment were unavailable.

Future investigations may include a photographic reconstruction of H-14 gatherings, a retrospective survey of biscuit-related incidents, and reunions.

6. Conclusion: The Research May End, but the Story Continues

Preetha came to CFTRI as a researcher, entered the laboratory as a senior, and gradually became something far more significant to the people around her. She worked hard, pursued scientific questions, travelled, photographed, celebrated, hosted, laughed, and cared.

Her legacy includes the work she pursued in the laboratory, the adventures she undertook beyond it, and the people who felt at home because of her. The campus trees will continue producing fruit, the canteen will continue its ordinary operations, and H-14 may eventually host new gatherings. Yet the people who shared this chapter will carry their version of it wherever they go. The most important outcomes of Preetha's PhD cannot be measured solely through scientific publications. They are also found in the people who felt at home because of her, the memories that still make her friends laugh, and the relationships that will continue long after the final experiment**.**

Acknowledgements

We acknowledge the Department of Microbiology for providing the scientific setting in which this story began; the laboratory for experiments, protocols, and conversations; the canteen for refreshments and its unwitting contribution to biscuit surveillance; the campus pathways and fruit-bearing trees; and the participants of Pictionary and dumb charades.

Special recognition goes to Quarters H-14, the unofficial headquarters of the CFTRI friendship collective. Thank you for hosting parties, laughter, games, festivals, and the comfort of being together.

Finally, we acknowledge Preetha. Thank you for being hardworking without losing your adventurous spirit; for your loyalty, compassion, expressive nature, and willingness to make other people's moments special. Thank you for opening your home and making people feel welcome.

This manuscript is dedicated to Preetha: the scientist who investigated UvrC, the friend who made H-14 unforgettable, and the person who helped turn a PhD journey into memories worth keeping forever.

Final Personal Note: To Our Preetha

Dear Preetha,

It is funny how a place can become so much more than a place. We first knew you as a senior in the laboratory. There were experiments to do, protocols to discuss, and a PhD to get through. None of us could have known how many memories would become attached to those ordinary days. We will remember the long campus walks, the guava, avocado, and star-fruit missions, and the canteen visits that may or may not have been motivated by biscuits. We will remember the games at H-14, the Pictionary drawings that made sense only to the person drawing them, and the dumb-charades performances that deserved awards for dramatic expression.

We will definitely remember the French bangs. Some experiments leave behind scientific discoveries. Others leave behind a story that refuses to die.

But beyond the funny incidents, we will remember how you made people feel at home. Not everyone knows how to bring people together, make celebrations special, open their doors, and turn an ordinary gathering into a memory that people carry for years. You do.

As you leave this chapter behind, we hope you know that the things you gave us were not limited to particular evenings, celebrations, or trips. You gave us a sense of belonging. You gave us reasons to laugh when life was difficult. You gave us memories that will become even more precious as the years pass.

May your next chapter bring you mountains to climb, places to explore, beautiful moments to photograph, meaningful work to pursue, and people who make you feel as loved as you have made us feel.

And no matter how far life takes us, we hope there will always be another reunion, another game of dumb charades, another reason to laugh about the French bangs, and another evening when we all find our way back to one another.

Your PhD journey at CFTRI may be coming to an end. But you will always have a place in our story.

With all our love, Your CFTRI family.